

A free gift for your family

Funeral wishes and papers workbook

Use this workbook to record what your family will need when you die -- and, if it comes to that, if you cannot make decisions for yourself.

It is not a will, a power of attorney, or a contract with a funeral home. Type in the fields, save the file, and give copies to people you trust. Tell them where the original is kept.

How to use it

- Type your answers in the fields on a computer or phone. Save the file. Print copies for people you trust. You can sign in ink after you print.
- Do not write passwords or full credit-card numbers. Name the bank or website, the last four digits if you need to tell accounts apart, and who can open your password manager.
- You can record funeral wishes here without paying a funeral home now. Prepaying is a separate decision.

1. Facts for the death certificate

The state asks for these facts on the certificate. Keep them together so no one is hunting under pressure.

First name	Middle name
Last name	Suffix (Jr., III)
Other names or nickname	Maiden name
Mother's maiden name	Father's name
Date of birth	City and state of birth
Last four of SSN (optional)	Marital status
Ethnic or cultural heritage (if the certificate asks)	Education / school
Spouse or partner (name)	
Date and place of marriage or union	

2. Family

Children (name, birth date, city)

Grandchildren or other dependents

Siblings (name)

3. Military service

I served in the armed forces

I did not serve

Branch and country

Rank at discharge

Service number

Dates of entry and discharge

Conflict or theater, if any

Where the DD-214 or discharge paper is

National cemetery? (confirm on VA.gov)

Military or lodge honors at the service

4. Whom to call first

First person to notify -- name and phone

Address

Additional contact -- name and phone

Others to notify (name and phone)

5. Who decides (executor, powers, professionals)

The executor and powers of attorney are signed on separate legal forms. Here you only record names so the family knows whom to find.

Executor -- name and phone

Co-executor

Financial power of attorney -- name

Health-care power of attorney -- name

Attorney -- name and phone

Accountant -- name and phone

Primary doctor

Specialist

Landlord if any

Employer if any

6. How the funeral can be paid

Check the paths that already exist. You do not need all of them.

Savings or payable-on-death account

Life / final expense policy

Prepaid funeral contract

The estate

Other (describe below)

Company or funeral home, plan or policy number, phone

Cemetery and plot number, if already owned

If there is no prepaid plan, who should compare funeral homes

7. What I want for my body and the service

The essentials are enough. Brand details are optional.

Traditional funeral, then burial or cremation

Direct burial or cremation, memorial later

Direct burial or cremation, no memorial

Body or organ donation (describe)

Other

Ground burial

Mausoleum or crypt

Cremation -- urn at home, niche, columbarium, or scattering (check local law)

National cemetery (VA eligibility)

Preferred funeral home or place of worship

Visitation: yes/no, open or closed casket, place

Officiant (first and second choice)

Photos, video, or other displays at the visitation

If you already chose a casket, urn, marker, or register book, write what the family should request (optional)

8. Clothing, flowers, music, and readings

Clothing and jewelry (if removed, whom to return them to)

Glasses: remain or return to family?

With flowers

No flowers -- donations to:

Organizations for gifts in lieu of flowers

Music, hymns, or no music

Readings, poems, or who gives the eulogy

9. Pallbearers and transportation

Pallbearers (up to six names)

Family transportation or other instructions

10. Notes for the obituary

Work, school, church, clubs, achievements

Preceded in death by / survived by

Newspapers or sites to publish

Include a photo: yes

Include a photo: no

11. Where the papers live

Write the location; do not copy the whole document.

Will

Advance directive / health POA

Financial power of attorney

Insurance policies

Birth certificate

Marriage / divorce papers

Deeds / vehicle titles

Military discharge

Passport / citizenship

Social Security card (location)

Trust documents, if any

Adoption papers / diplomas

Safe-deposit key (who holds it)

Driver's license (location, not the number)

I have a will

I do not have a will yet

Date of will and who the executor is

12. Insurance

Company, type (term, whole life, group), policy number, beneficiary, phone. Not the portal username.

Policy 1

Policy 2

13. Banks, debts, and property (no passwords)

Banks (name, branch, account type, last four)

Retirement / pension / 401(k) -- company and administrator

Brokerage / investments (company and last four, no passwords)

Real estate and vehicles (description and where the title is)

Mortgage or other loans (lender and phone)

14. Online accounts (no passwords)

Site, username, and WHERE the password is stored (do not write it)

15. Words for my family

Message**16. Signature**

I sign this workbook so my family knows these are my preferences. It does not replace a will or a power of attorney in my state. I ask that they honor it as far as the law and the circumstances allow.

Printed name

Signature

Date

Optional notary: this does not turn the workbook into a will.

Notary stamp space (optional)

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